

Epilogue

“... Hey, Mama. *Amme*.” Standing at the foot of a pair of simple stone markers was Aya, beloved daughter of Kireh and Elyssa and member of the Clockwork Contingent. She’d set these makeshift gravesites up on Helinwa Rock, the homestead of the Asato family. *Their* family.

“It’s.. been awhile, huh?” Aya paused; if she’d been able to cry, she would already be doing so. “A year now, to the day. That... wasn’t a coincidence. It’s been rough. It still is. I still think about you—about *us*—every day. How we almost made it. And I... I kept putting this day off. I don’t want to say goodbye.

“I’ve kept busy. For those first months, I tried desperately to fix things. To bring you back, to bring Lyania back. So many times, I wished to myself that just... somehow, you’d be back. The *Starwasp* would have somehow dodged, the targeting ring would misfire, that the Eye would just find you or us too interesting to stop watching, to just let you die. Maybe it snatched you away at the last second and planned to return you if I just searched hard enough. Months, Mama, *Amme*. Soluna and I searched for months. Even now, she and Nylos are out there, scouring old Asrian ruins for some kind of miracle.

“I haven’t given up. I still want to be reunited, to have our family back together. But...” Aya closed her eyes and heaved a great sigh—or as close as her construct body could approximate. “I’ve seen the cycle of life and death. I helped fix it. Even if I don’t really understand it... I know. By now, you’ve probably already moved on. And you deserve it. If anyone deserves to finally rest, to heal and move on, it’s you two. It almost feels cruel at this point to pull you back. Selfish, even.” Aya fell to her knees, her voice breaking down even though the tears couldn’t flow.

“And that’s my problem. I’m so, so selfish. I’ve always wanted to have it my way. I... I wanted to save everyone. *Everything*. I didn’t want to kill every Clockwork, I didn’t want to destroy their planet. I just... wanted to stop them. To do it in the least destructive way possible, so that the pieces could be picked up when it was all done. We had a weapon. One that could destroy not just the planet, but enough of space that nearby systems would be affected. And I wanted to find a way to not use it. I *pushed* for this plan, this idea where we’d go into the planet and shut it down, kill their leaders and destroy their facilities so they couldn’t do it again. *Millions* of people died, *YOU* died, all because I wasn’t willing to use the bomb except as a last resort. If I had just gone myself, just me and the bomb, timer active, I *know* I could have made it to the planet and blown it up. I didn’t need to get to the core. No one else would’ve had to die. And now... it’s too late. There are no magic wishes, no changing the past, no tearing apart the afterlife to pull you back. I... need to move on. To let go. Not just for me—for everyone who’s suffering. I couldn’t protect them, but maybe I can help heal the wounds. But I can’t do that if I keep focusing on my hurt, and on helping just those I care about.” As Aya averted her eyes, unable to even look up at her parents’ graves, footsteps approached from behind her.

“Mom? It’s almost time to go; are you ready?” The gravelly voice behind her belonged to Dave. Aya gave a slight smile; they weren’t on a strict time schedule at all. He’d probably come over just to remind her that she wasn’t alone.

“Just a few more minutes, sweetie. Thanks. If you want, you can go make sure the *Asato* is ready to go.” Aya stood back up and brushed herself off, then gave Dave a reassuring smile. He gave her a thumbs up—he still didn’t have a mouth to smile back with, but he didn’t seem to mind.

"I guess I didn't really explain what I've been up to since I stopped searching, did I? Well, for one, as you heard, I finally figured out how to get Dave's voice working. It's not perfect, and he's still getting used to it, but... it works." Aya's voice grew quiet. "I know we promised to work on that together, but... it didn't seem fair to make him wait any longer. Especially if you can't come back. I'm also starting to work on refining his design; he's been using spare Clockwork parts for so long, I figured I should start making custom ones to help him work better.

"Oh! Speaking of making parts, I fixed my foot! Back when my friends and I first came back home after the original attack, Nylos grabbed a bunch of papers and stuff from the house before the Horrors came back. I was digging through them and found some of the old blueprints you'd used to make me. Most of them weren't for the final iteration that became me, but my feet didn't change much. I was able to whip those up pretty quickly, so now your daughter's got matching boots again!" Aya laughed—a hollow laugh, but somewhere inside, part of her felt it could've been real.

"I also fixed the house." Aya glanced back at the tower; it was blocky, made primarily of massive cubes of stone assembled roughly in the shape of the home that had been razed to ashes where it stood. "It's not perfect; I'm nowhere near as artistic as you two were. But it functions. If... if you come back while I'm gone, it'll be here waiting for you. For me, too. I'm not planning on leaving forever—I'll be back one day, and maybe I'll see you here.

"I think you'd be excited if you were here. You know, we were going to fix up that old spelljamming helm that *Amme* got and one day have our own spelljammer, but it was lost in the attack. I found a broken one on my travels, too, but I left it with Miji after I fixed it—gave him a few lessons, too. I don't know if he'll ever use it, but he was the only one without a ship of his own. Well, him and me. That wasn't a problem, though." Aya grinned and looked behind her; anchored on the side of Helinwa Rock was a crude ship, just as blocky as the house. On the deck was Dave, directing a wiry wooden construct with a gem in its chest and a squat, crab-like construct to move some boxes of supplies below deck. "I made my own. Our own family ship—the *Asato*, so you'll always be with me. It's rough and not particularly comfortable for more... *organic* creatures, at the moment, but I'm going to fix that. It's space-worthy, though, and it's something I can be proud of." Aya's voice grew quieter again as she muttered under her breath: "Something built for peace, not for war.

"Anyway, we're preparing to head out. Currently, the crew is all constructs, like myself. We're on our way to Gith space—or what used to be, anyway. They... lost a lot, during the battle. More than most. They're on the verge of extinction, both them and the solar dragons. You know, I fought an ancient one once—with the Clockwork Contingent. We earned his respect in a trial by combat... the trial that convinced the Gith to join the fight instead of just letting us through. The trial that killed most of them...

"I'm sorry. I'm trying not to stay too focused on the negatives. It's just going to take a long time. I'm going to try to meet with some of the Gith leaders and the elder dragon; we're trying to formulate a plan to gather as many Gith and solar dragons as we can, then claim a sanctuary planet for them to be safe and begin to rebuild their society. I'm planning to offer my aid, however I can. Maybe one day, they'll be happy and flourishing again.

"On the way, I'm planning to try to stop by and visit Uncle Utron. Miji managed to get his patron to free him, so he's back. I'm not sure if he's going to go back to being a pirate, or if he has other plans, but I figured I'd visit and invite him to join me on the trip if he wants. I'm not sure how long it will be—Gith

space was massive before, and they're likely scattered very far apart. He might not want to come along for a long ride, but I figured I'd invite him anyway. He's... kind of like family, you know?"

Aya sighed, looking wishfully at the pair of stones. Overhead, a space guppy passed by; a whole school was likely nearby, traveling through the area at this time of year. Time kept ticking forward, even when she wished it wouldn't. It'd been a year, and she still wasn't ready.

"I guess... it's time, huh? Time for me to stop holding on and... move on. Time for me to go." As Aya turned towards the *Asato*, she looked back over her shoulder at the pair of graves one last time.

"Goodbye, Mama, *Amme*. I'll see you again one day."